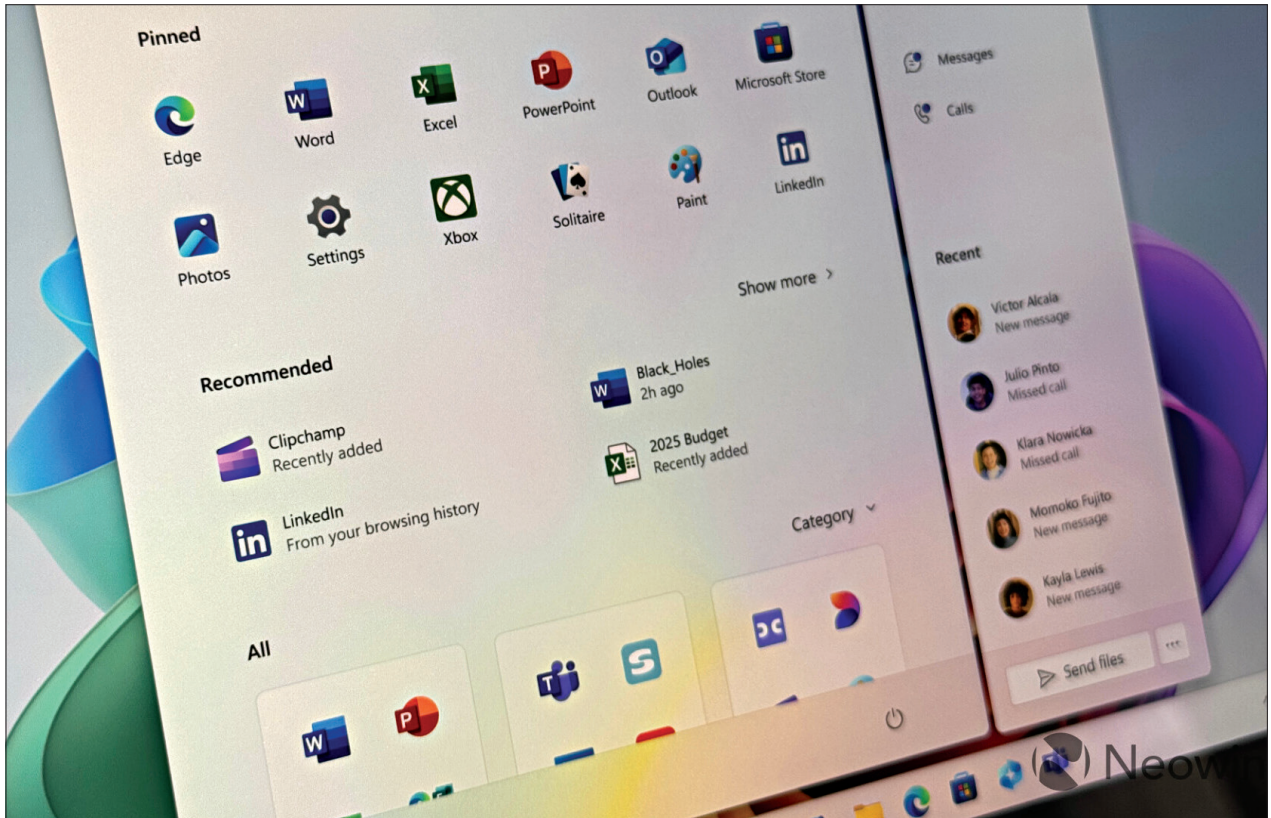




The Start Menu lie

Stop letting Start waste your screen space, daily

Windows 11's Start menu looks friendly. It sits politely in the middle of the taskbar, smiles at you with a grid of icons, and then quietly nudges you into a workflow you didn't choose: "Recommended" files you didn't ask for, suggestions that feel like ads, and a layout that's optimised for Microsoft's idea of you – not your actual day.

For Indian users, this matters because Start is the gateway drug to everything you do on a laptop: lecture PDFs, Office files, WhatsApp Web, government portals, banking, coding tools, and the occasional "why is my Wi-Fi dead again?" troubleshooting sprint. If Start is noisy, you lose time. If Start is predictable, you gain momentum.

This chapter is about taking control of Start and the taskbar – without installing third-party "tweakers", without registry

gymnastics, and without turning your laptop into a science experiment. We'll do three things:

1. Rebuild Start so it opens to the apps you actually use.
2. Kill (or at least shrink) the recommendation noise.
3. Make the taskbar and system tray behave like a tool, not a billboard.

1) Find which Start you have

Windows 11's Start has been evolving. Microsoft has tested and rolled out a redesigned Start menu that's bigger, scrollable, brings "All apps" into the main Start view, and (crucially) adds the ability to hide the Recommended section in that newer layout.

How to tell quickly:

- If "All apps" opens a *separate view*, you have the older Start.